COMM 3180

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ARE THE #OSCARSSOWHITE? ANALYZING ACADEMY AWARD DEMOGRAPHICS AND #OSCARSSOWHITE CAMPAIGN EFFICACY

Project Idea

- Measure whether the #OscarsSoWhite social media campaign (2015–2016) produced a lasting, quantifiable shift in Oscar nomination diversity, box office performance of films with diverse leads, and cultural conversation

RQs

- How have POC nomination and win rates changed over time?
- Did POC nomination rates in acting and directing categories increase significantly after 2016?
- Do films with POC leads earn differently at the box office than white-lead films, and did that relationship change post-2016?
- How, if at all, has #OscarsSoWhite influenced the cultural discourse surrounding Academy Award diversity?

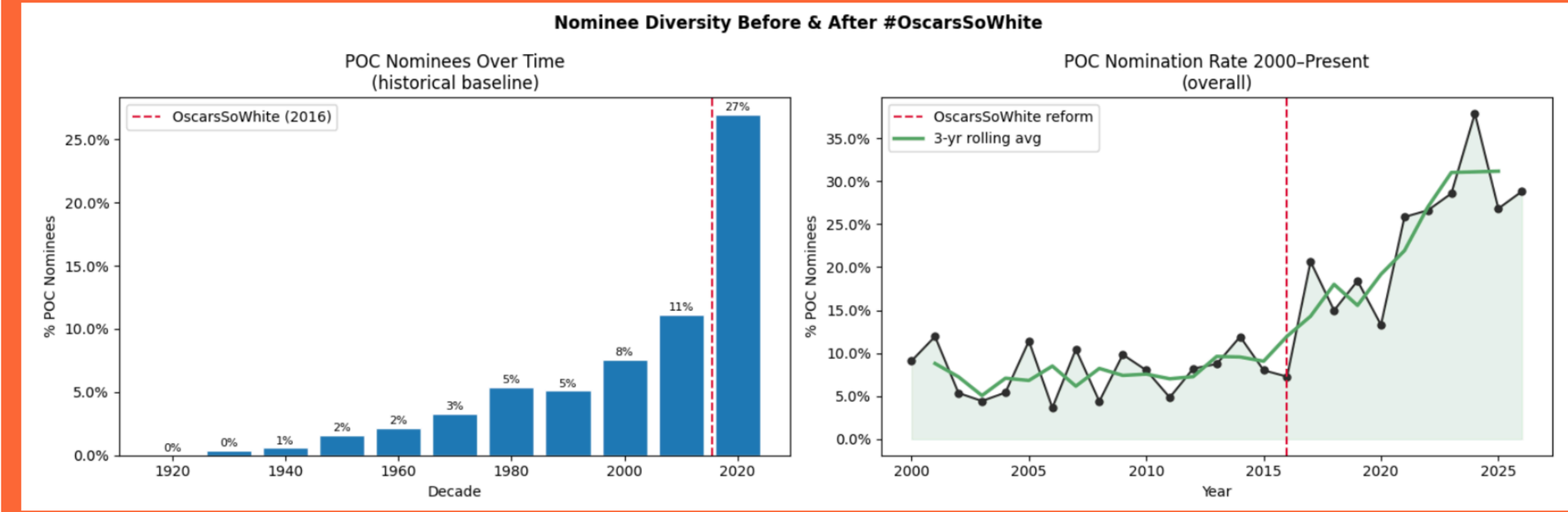
Hypotheses

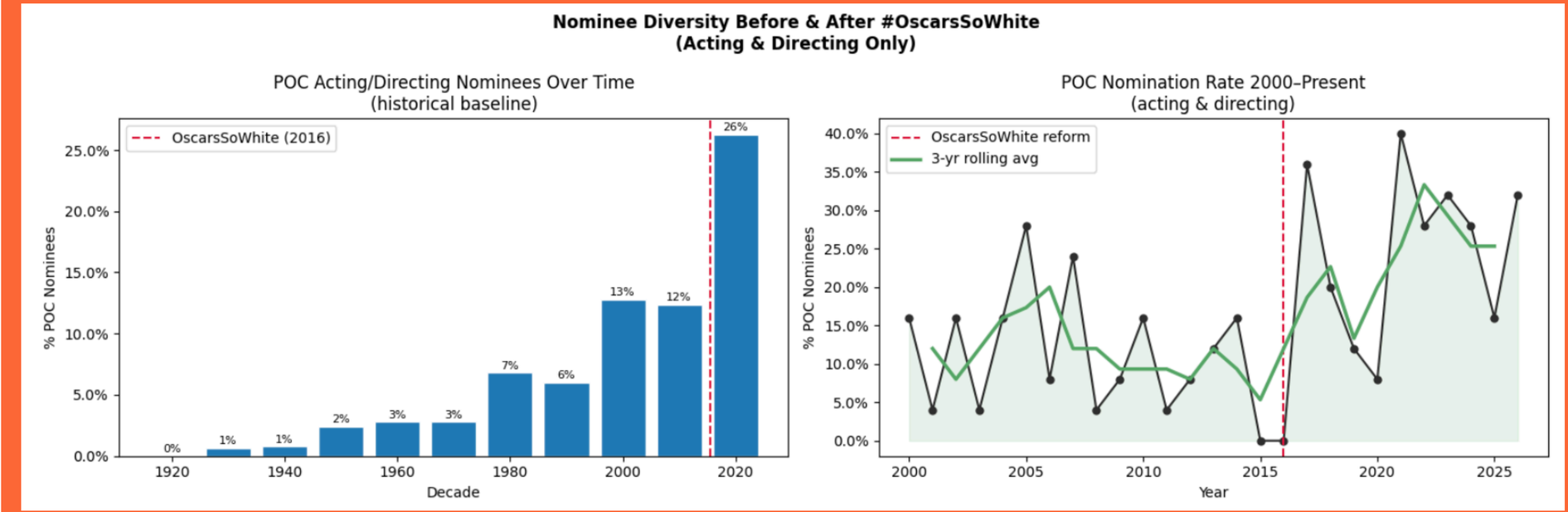
- POC nomination rates increased significantly post-2016, driven by the Academy's membership expansion rather than gradual organic change.
- Pre-2016, POC-lead nominees earned less domestically than white-lead nominees; post-2016 that gap narrowed as the Academy nominated higher-profile diverse films.

DATA SOURCES

- Number of tweets containing #OscarsSoWhite from 2015-2021
- Sample of tweets containing #OscarsSoWhite from 2015-2021
  - Wharton & Annenberg Twitter Archive.
- Google Trends Data
- Box Office Data
  - Kaggle
- Oscar Nomination + wins data (two separate datasets, merged + completed using Claude)
  - Kaggle

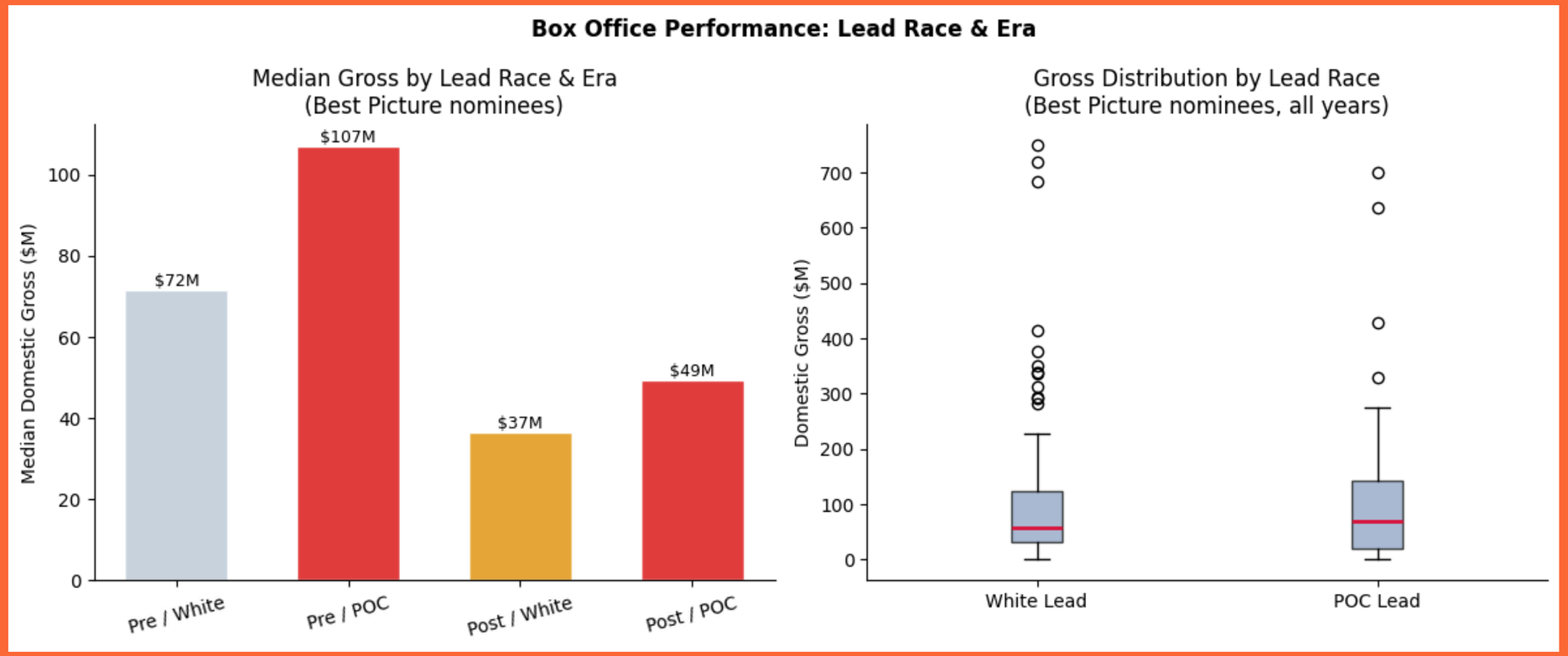
NOMINATION DIVERSITY ANALYSES





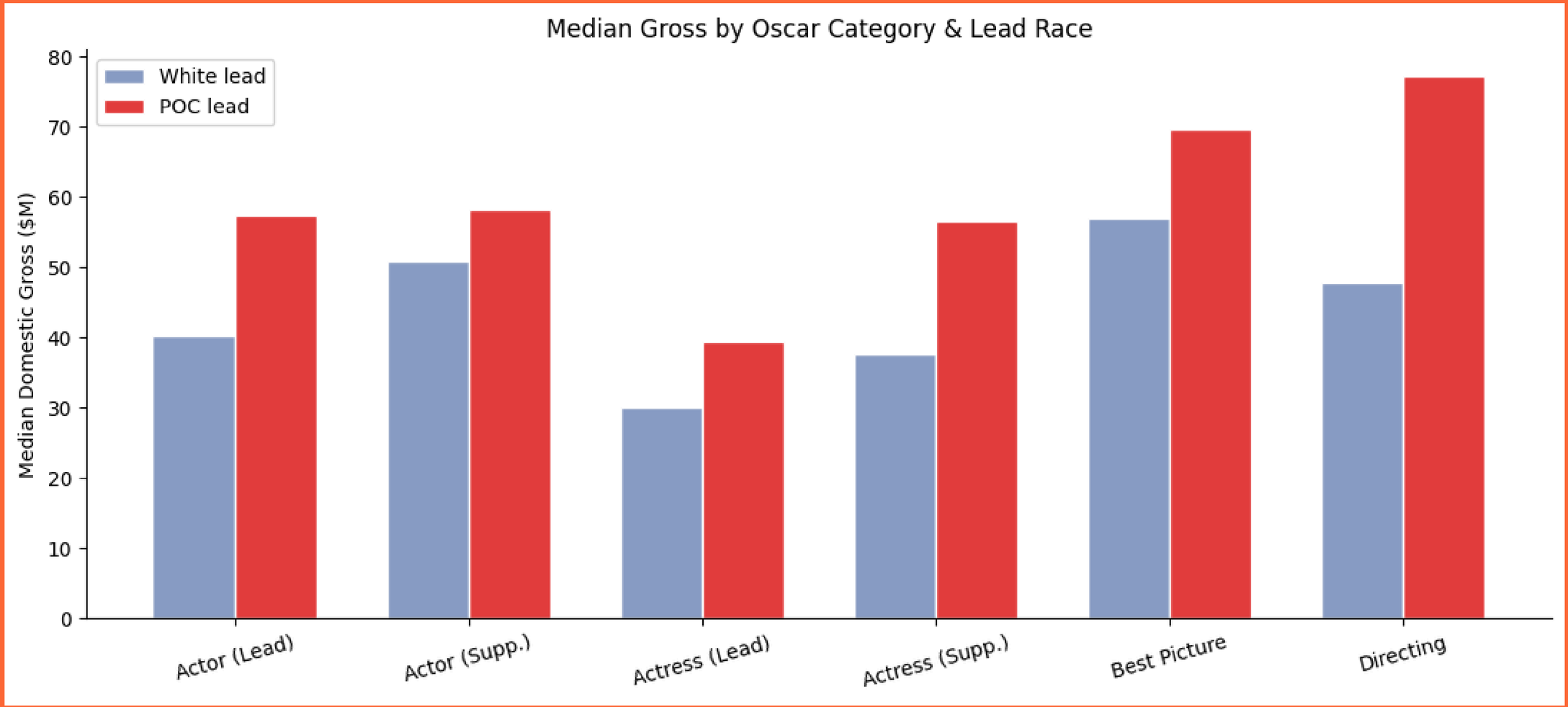
- Overall increase over time, exponential increase in 21st century
- Diversity of overall nominations has increased steadily over the century, while the diversity of acting and directing nominations appears to vary more from year to year
- All the acting and directing nominees in 2015, the year before the hashtag #OscarsSoWhite was popularized, were white

BOX OFFICE ANALYSIS

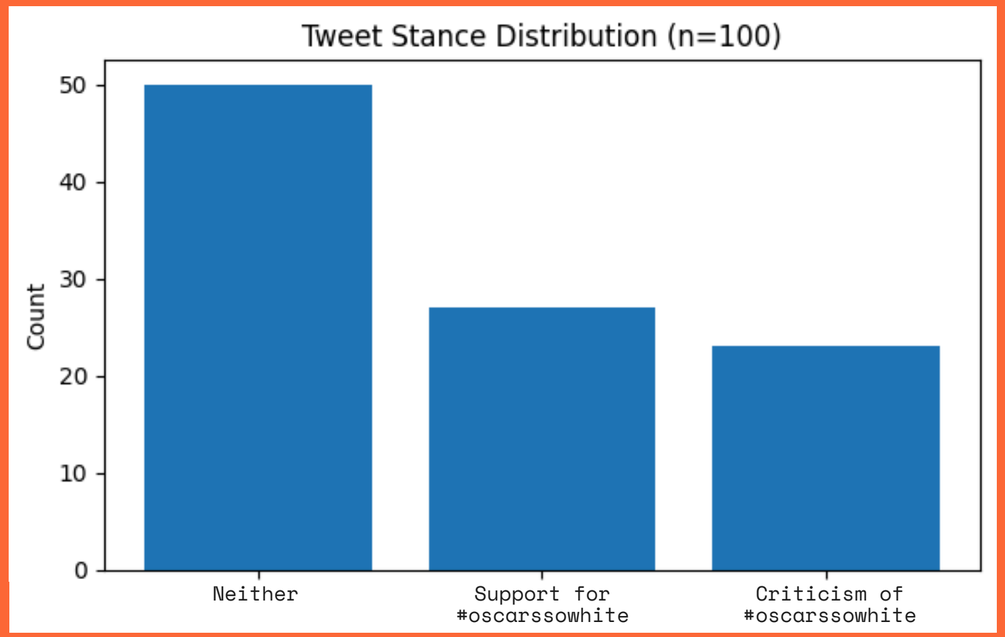


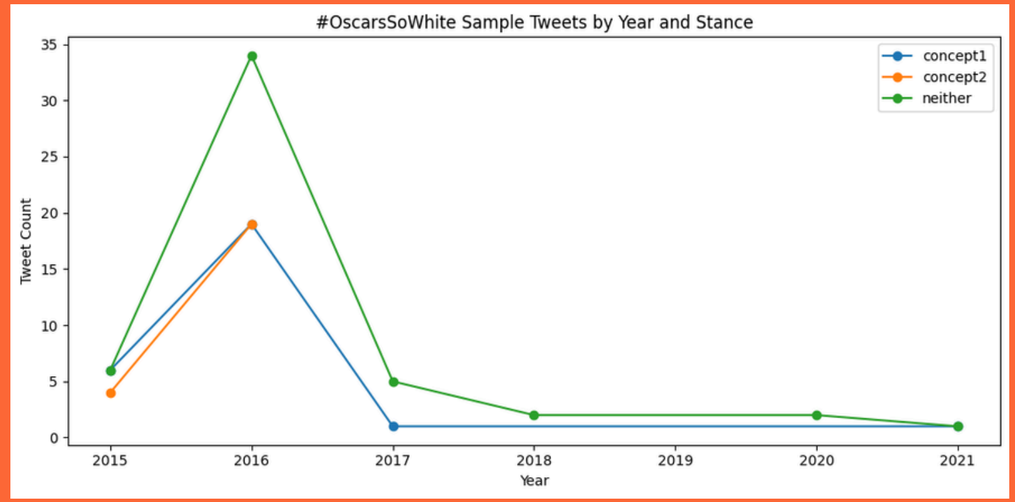
- Box office performance down overall
- POC led movies historically and currently outperform

BOX OFFICE ANALYSIS



AUDIENCE ANALYSIS





DISTRIBUTION OF #OSCARSSOWHITE TWEETS FROM 2015-2022

- Hand-coded a sample size of 100 tweets in either support or criticism of #OscarsSoWhite
- Found most tweets were neutral news articles, spam, unreadable retweets, etc.
- Criticism also included the lack of advocacy for Asian and Hispanic diversity in the Oscars, something the #OscarsSoWhite lacked.

EMERGENT STORY

- Audiences took note and collectively voiced their frustration through #Oscars-so-White in 2015-2016. POC nomination rates spiked in 2016 and the average has never returned to pre-campaign levels, with POC winners reaching 42.7% in the 2020s.
- In spite of diverse films already winning at the box office, the Academy has spent decades nominating them at a fraction of the rate of white-led films. Across every major Oscar category, POC lead films matched or exceeded the median gross of white-lead films.
- Though the #OscarsSoWhite helped lead the conversation surrounding diversity in Oscar nominations, the campaign might not have adequately addressed members of all racial minority groups equally.

NEXT PLANNED STEPS

- Feed coded tweets (n=100) of support/criticism of #OscarsSoWhite to an LLM to code an entire dataset to create a more robust analysis.
- Research Google Trends data to identify when #OscarsSoWhite, Oscar's diversity, and other related search terms were trending.
- Identify how long after the Oscars that #OscarsSoWhite was discussed to see if diversity was a long-standing issue or simply a trend.